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The Future of American Foreign Policy

Contemporary Assessment

FAANG, MANGO. The evolution of American technological dominance, once represented by the supremacy of Facebook, Apple, Amazon, Netflix, and Google (FAANG), has shifted with the rise of AI and industry rebranding to the era of Meta, Apple, Nvidia, Google, and OpenAI (MANGO). This transition marks more than a job-market phenomenon—it signals a strategic transformation in how America asserts global power, relying increasingly on technological control and innovation. As the contest for hegemony moves beyond traditional statecraft, the ability to shape information and intelligence systems becomes central to projecting American influence and maintaining leadership on the world stage.

Science and technology are a foundational element of global U.S. power. They create the capacity for creating systems that don't just stay in the United States; they move outwards and shape how the world works. If you author a system, you determine its rules. For instance, the Defense Advanced Research Projects Agency (DARPA) helped invent the internet with the launch of ARPANET in 1969, laying the foundation for today's global network (DARPA). The internet itself runs on American ideas and technology, with carveouts for countries like Russia and China that built similar systems.

The "Big Beautiful Bill" emphasized boosting U.S. tech manufacturing, tightening federal cybersecurity standards, and expanding partnerships with private firms to secure national infrastructure (Sayegh). But while these measures aim to secure American infrastructure, they also highlight a deeper truth: the contest for technological leadership extends beyond borders, shaping not just domestic resilience but global influence. As Abu Bakr Alremeh observes, the global race for power has entered a new dimension with the rise of data and informatics – a new weapon that shapes individuals' choices often without them even realizing it, earning it a reputation as the "new oil." In this sense, the contest over AI chips and data systems is not just economic competition, but a struggle over who will set the rules of global governance in the decades ahead.

As the U.S. faces realities of declining international power, new technology and AI arms races provide a path to invest domestically while leading internationally. But this opportunity comes at the cost of giving tech companies a greater role in governance, where chasing this high-reward potential comes with a great risk of placing private interests above the public good. While vast networks and powerful connections are nothing new to tech-industry giants, unlike the FAANG era, MANGO's leaders are now

fixtures in Washington. They stood behind federal podiums during President Trump's 2025 inauguration (Swenson), a symbol of how corporate tech has fused with American governance at a never-before-seen level. This image of corporate and state power as one at the Executive branch is not merely symbolic; it has also reached the Legislative Branch and is written directly into U.S. defense planning. Congress's 2023 *Cyber Strategy of the Department of Defense* emphasizes public-private partnerships, threat deterrence, and readiness against cyberattacks from hostile actors like China and Russia. This directly shows how the government itself defines and relies on partnerships with private tech companies, expecting them to function as extensions of state capacity even while they remain unelected and privately driven. The very policies designed to secure America's global position risk eroding the democratic accountability that once distinguished U.S. leadership.

The primary challenge is maintaining American technological leadership without compromising democratic principles or international standing. Leading firms such as Microsoft, Amazon, and Tencent influence global geopolitics by providing essential infrastructure, establishing technology standards, and shaping foreign policy, which can impact international conflicts, such as the war in Ukraine (Kurth). This dynamic illustrates the close connection between private-sector capabilities and foreign policy. While the role of technology firms in global affairs is not new, the influence of high-profile CEOs has become more pronounced. For instance, Ukraine's dependence on Elon Musk's Starlink satellites highlights the risk: senior officials must rely on the interests of business leaders, whose goals may not always align with national policy priorities (Newman, Farrell). Other companies, including Palantir and Clearview, have deployed innovative surveillance technologies in conflict zones, raising concerns about privacy and public accountability. These developments emphasize how private technological power now plays a significant role on the world stage, influencing both policy and outcomes alongside elected officials.

This reflects a shift in U.S. power and governance, where the pursuit of technological dominance now directly jeopardizes the American public. Governments are funding research and forging alliances with companies whose products shape the daily lives of millions. Unlike in the Cold War, when the U.S. sought technological dominance through a set of policies driven by massive federal investments in university research, the National Science Foundation, and the NIH, today's investments are in Large Language Models and social media platforms. OpenAI recently received a \$200 million defense contract to “develop prototype frontier AI capabilities to address critical national security challenges in both warfighting and enterprise domains,” the Defense Department said (Novet). This creates a paradox: in building powerful data systems to influence others, the U.S. risks influence at home to the very companies it relies on. The 2024 presidential election revealed this danger vividly, as Elon Musk used political spending and his platform, X (formerly Twitter), to amplify his influence on the outcome – ultimately

securing constant visibility in the White House and even a role through his self-styled Department of Governmental Efficiency.

Extending beyond traditional state-to-state relations, American leadership must hold firmly to democratic values as power shifts toward unelected corporate leaders. These companies cannot be allowed to steer U.S. policy by imposing foreign influences. Yet Amazon, Apple, Meta, and Nvidia have already pressured both the Biden and Trump administrations to shield their business models from international regulation. For example, when Canada pushed tech platforms to compensate news outlets for content, Meta responded by blocking Canadian news during a wildfire emergency. This incident highlights how corporate decisions motivated by profit prioritize business and the public good, including for U.S. allies. When American leadership defends corporate partners over state allies, it weakens alliances, damages international reputation, and signals that unelected companies hold greater sway in policy than the American people.

In order to shape norms while maintaining a competitive advantage, America must first undo damaging norms put into place by the Trump Administration, which emboldened tech companies to shoo away governing interference. “As Sam Altman, the CEO of OpenAI, admitted in 2023 congressional testimony, “A.I. could go quite wrong... We want to work with the government to prevent that from happening.” Yet since Trump’s election, many tech leaders have reversed course with bold requests of the government to stay out of their way (Kang). Beyond the norms of one President, tech companies today are able to resist government interference through lobbying efforts, policy-oriented lawsuits, and public campaigns. Aiming to repair harmful Trump administration norms should be used as a catalyst for addressing greater systemic issues.

As global competition in technology accelerates, the United States faces both opportunities and risks in leveraging technological innovation for influence. The legacy of DARPA’s contributions to the internet demonstrates the power of technology in promoting American culture and values internationally. Continued advancements could allow the United States to further such influence. Nonetheless, longstanding domestic challenges—including issues in healthcare, public safety, and governance—continue to impact the nation’s reputation abroad.

America should follow Obama’s model of progressive pragmatism, mixing Wilsonian multilateralism and Jeffersonian restraint. This approach would bring back the audacity of hope, restoring American status internationally while also working to address domestic concerns. It is progressive enough to recognize the values of technology, but pragmatic to see the risks it brings to democracy. Rejoining international agreements like the Paris Climate Accord would signal a renewed commitment to cooperation. Also, leading efforts to establish a global framework for AI governance would place the U.S. at the head of setting democratic norms for modern technologies. Both of these would earn mutual

respect, which equals more willing partners and U.S. leadership. However, at the same time, this leadership must be paired with a paramount domestic focus to ensure that the city, state, or the nation as a whole is not under the unchecked influence of big tech. By balancing these traditions and commitments, America can find success in adapting out of the “hyperpower” era, protecting democracy, and using technology for continued power.

Historical Foundations

Through American history, foreign policy has always been a tug-of-war between different historical traditions and transitional eras. The current state of rapidly advancing AI technologies mirrors past moments when the United States was forced to rethink its role in the world. Just as the Cold War demanded industrial partnerships and technological innovation beyond status quo diplomacy, today’s AI race requires a blend of historical lessons and new strategies. As the U.S. steps into a new era of information, the past contains valuable lessons from previous foreign endeavors, transitional periods, and ideological traditions. American leadership must draw on historical traditions of economic statecraft and multilateralism while staying clear of militarism and ideological overreach. To secure leadership and democracy in the age of AI and informatics, the U.S. must adapt its framework to channel Hamiltonian innovation and Wilsonian cooperation towards governing technology, setting global norms, and weaving democracy into the fabric of the information age.

Several aspects of American historical foreign policy remain valuable today. The 2029 Administration can draw on these traditions to create continuity while adapting them for a contemporary stage. Most notably, the Hamiltonian approach, prioritizing national strength through economic and technological capacities, and pragmatic foreign diplomacy, applies directly to the current national environment, fueled by technological power and AI-driven competition. The U.S. has historically leveraged markets, innovation, and economic power as foreign policy tools. During the Cold War, the U.S. created a Military Industrial Academic Complex, launching policies that boosted science and technology dominance through massive federal investments in research and development: university research programs, National Science Foundation, National Institutes of Health (NIH) (Turse). These efforts increased innovation in computing, fueling breakthroughs such as ARPANET, the precursor to the modern internet. Reviving this Hamiltonian logic, the 2029 Administration should seek partnerships and investments with universities and research institutions, rather than threatening them like the Trump administration, to strengthen U.S. leadership in AI innovation and governance.

Following the post-Cold War era, as Mead observes, “The Hamiltonian school lost its way in the ‘end of history’ optimism of the early post–Cold War era, but the pressures of a more sober era in world history are leading to a rediscovery of the foundational ideas that make the Hamiltonian tradition an essential component of successful American foreign policy.” As power shifts to technology and

information, the Hamiltonian framework offers a tested path towards American leadership through strong relationships between business and government, economic alliances, and open markets.

Moreover, in the 19th Century, Secretary of State John Hay's Open Door Policy exemplified the importance of the Hamiltonian open market through a series of notes. These notes promoted free and equal trading opportunities in China, respect for China's sovereignty, and expressed U.S. hopes for cooperation with other great powers (U.S. Department of State). Hay argued that equal access to commerce was crucial for the success of American businesses and the U.S. economy. Today, it remains paramount for the U.S. to maintain equal access to opportunities regarding AI and technology. American leadership should once again signal to its allies and rivals for an even economic playing field, building on respect for other countries' individuality and sovereignty. The 2029 Administration could tackle this by putting forward a similar "Open Repository Policy" at international organizations such as the Organisation for Economic Co-operation and Development (OECD) or the World Trade Organization (WTO), aiming to make equal access to key emerging markets like India and Brazil for the AI innovation ecosystem.

Building on the need for international cooperation, utilizing the Wilsonian tradition underscores the importance of multilateral diplomacy as a cornerstone of American leadership. This tradition has historically served to align U.S. leadership through cooperative initiatives like the League of Nations and later the UN framework. Likewise, innovation in AI will go beyond software discussions, requiring actors to establish government systems that allow for economic growth while managing risks and preserving democratic principles. To strive for multilateralism, the U.S. must first reflect past departures from the Wilsonian tradition, such as twice withdrawing from the Paris Climate Accord, abandoning the Iran nuclear deal, undermining trust with NATO allies through threats of withdrawal and unilateral tariff wars, and even making remarks about buying allied nations like Canada. A new administration can act quickly, making public comments to domestic and international audiences, creating domestic political costs to boost credibility and constrain future policy reversals. Following these pledges, rejoining the Paris Climate Accord would restore reputation and allow the U.S. to lead on new agreements concerning AI governance, digital markets, and cybersecurity.

Whilst pursuing economic expansion and international diplomacy, the U.S. must be cautious of avoiding Jacksonian militarism and overreaching the ideological spread from Mendelbaum's themes. The Jacksonian mentality, colorfully described in lecture as 'opening a can of whoop-ass,' runs into problems in a global context where not every actor shares American nationalist priorities. Jacksonian instincts often dismiss diplomacy in favor of honor-based security, and when military force is used, it is applied overwhelmingly and decisively. While this approach proved fruitful in existential conflicts like WWII, it fails when applied to complex transnational challenges such as AI governance, which cannot be solved by

force. Similarly, Mendelbaum's vision of exporting democracy, from Clinton's "Enlargement" strategy to Bush's Invasion of Iraq, attempts to forcibly impose American values abroad have repeatedly fallen short with no enduring success. Even for the world's strongest hegemon, overestimating America's ability to remake societies has produced costly wars, destabilized regions, and eroded U.S. credibility. As the U.S. exits its "hyperpower" era, replicating this approach in the digital domain would be even more damaging, risking perceptions of neo-imperialism and undermining global trust. Particularly, when combined, military nationalism and ideological overreach are even more dangerous. When combined, military-nationalism and ideological overreach create a particularly dangerous formula, one that could derail U.S. efforts to lead on cooperative AI governance and deepen global mistrust.

American foreign policy has always adapted in response to new forms of power. Today, as technology and data reshape global influence, the U.S. must draw on the strengths of its traditions while avoiding past mistakes. Hamiltonian economic statecraft and Wilsonian multilateralism provide grounds for securing AI leadership through self-investment, cooperation, and norm-setting. At the same time, resisting Jacksonian militarism and ideological overreach are vital to avoid repeating failures in Iraq or hubris from the U.S.'s "hyperpower" era. As our lectures warned through the "Icarus complex," overestimating American capacity to remake systems can lead to self-inflicted decline. The future of American leadership can soar again, but only if it avoids flying too close to the sun.

In October 2022, the Biden administration initiated export controls restricting China's access to advanced semiconductors. Since then, the U.S. has broadened the scope to include high-bandwidth memory, AI model weights, and the activities of U.S. persons supporting Chinese chip facilities (Fernandez and Lyall). The stated goal is to prevent military AI development and maintain the U.S. technological edge.

This policy challenge presents multiple pathways for American leadership to choose, each carrying its own distinct trade-offs. First, the U.S. could choose to employ targeted controls with allied coordination. This approach would seek to restrict only the most sensitive technologies, such as advanced AI chips for military applications and high-bandwidth memory, while aligning export control policies with key partners like Japan, South Korea, and the Netherlands. Additionally, engaging trusted allies such as Canada, Australia, and other European Union members can strengthen diplomatic legitimacy and enhance multilateral enforcement. Coordinated action would keep U.S. firms competitive and show a commitment to cooperative rule-making instead of acting alone. The downside of this approach is that multilateral engagement requires willing partners. Significant diplomatic effort could take time and still allow some technology to slip through other countries.

A second option would be for the U.S. to act unilaterally and expand export controls as much as possible. This would include banning all advanced AI chips, cloud services, and access to open-source

model weights for China, while penalizing any company or individual that violates these restrictions. Support for this measure argues that it is the quickest and most reliable way to ensure some level of success in blocking China's military AI development and protecting U.S. security interests. However, this approach risks damaging American tech companies by cutting them off from global markets, straining alliances and reputation, and creating a greater rift between the U.S. and China.

In terms of American foreign policy, these two options are full of traditions and frameworks used throughout different eras. The first option shows strong connections to Wilsonian multilateralism, focusing on collective action over acting alone. This cooperative approach also looks to sustain global market access in order to protect innovation, supporting Hamiltonian economic statecraft. Additionally, this approach avoids harmful traditions like Jacksonian militarism, making it well-balanced for the current era.

Conversely, the second option reflects opposite beliefs. Acting individually promotes Jacksonian instincts that prioritize nationalist strength and self-reliance over diplomacy. Furthermore, it avoids harmful traditions such as Jacksonian militarism and patterns of ideological overreach that Mandelbaum identified in U.S. foreign policy, where the pursuit of spreading American values often exceeded practical limits. From a Hamiltonian perspective, this undermines both pragmatic foreign policy and long-term economic competitiveness by severing U.S. ties from global markets, while its refusal to Wilsonian cooperation erodes trust among allies and possibilities of leadership.

While acting unilaterally might seem more certain because it avoids reliance on allies, such an approach sacrifices long-term influence and risks deepening global fragmentation. I argue that to secure leadership and embed democratic principles in AI and semiconductor governance, the U.S. must employ a Hamiltonian and Wilsonian framework focused on strategic investments, multilateral policy-making, and global norm-setting.

To carry out this approach, the 2029 administration should take the lead on creating an Allied Semiconductor and AI Framework under OECD leadership. Focusing on the OECD rather than military alliances like NATO, the Quad, or AUKUS avoids framing this as a military problem and prevents the slide toward Jacksonian militarism. Working with key partners in the semiconductor supply chain and trusted allies would keep diplomacy efficient and reliable. This framework could expand over time, allowing additional countries to join as they recognize the benefits of coordinated access, security assurances, and shared standards. Ultimately, it would protect market access and domestic innovation while putting America at the forefront of AI technology leadership. Building on this, U.S. leadership should invest in a Hamiltonian military-academic-industrial collaboration with universities and national tech organizations. This would ensure innovation is threaded with democratic oversight and accountability, avoiding excessive influence from powerful tech companies or their leaders.

This approach balances democracy and innovation while reinforcing U.S. leadership through cooperation and setting the standard rather than unilateral dominance. While executing this vision, U.S. leadership should be prepared for external events that can derail even the best-laid plans and the realities of domestic constraints limiting international ambitions. To overcome these challenges, the U.S. can still lead by investing in both cooperating with allies and domestic innovation guardrails, the U.S. can foster leadership and global AI norms without military and ideological overreach.

AI Attribution Statement

Portions of this paper were refined using AI-based tools, including ChatGPT (OpenAI) for thesaurus purposes, structural suggestions, and organizing outlines and thoughts, and Grammarly for grammar and style corrections. All substantive ideas, arguments, and final decisions about content and organization are my own.

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